

Finiteness in Atlantic Creoles revisited

Creole languages have extensively been studied whether in relation or in opposition to their lexifiers and/or other natural languages. Some linguists have considered creoles to represent an “exceptional” category, separate from all other natural languages in the world (see Hall 1966, DeGraff 2001, Chaudenson 2003, Lefebvre 2000, Mufwene 1999 and Winford 2005 among others), whereas other linguists found that creole languages, while showing striking similarities with one another, are not as “exceptional” as they look (see McWhorter 2001, 2005; Parkvall 2008; Bakker et al. 2011 among others). While these two somewhat opposing views have spread in many areas of study in Creole linguistics, for our current study, we wish to focus exclusively on how Atlantic creoles compare to Indo-European lexifiers with regards to their complementation system, as well as to the notion of finiteness.

In their study, Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) sought to defend the position that the basilects of Indo-European Pidgins and Creoles (IEPCs), unlike their lexifiers, show no finite/nonfinite distinction, “therefore no infinitives,” (p.297) and thus “follow their own pattern.” (p.304) To support their claim, the authors analyzed raising/control constructions as well as complements of purposive prepositions and complementizers *pu* (Koopman 1986 for Haitian Creole (HC)), *pa* (Dijkhoff 1983 for Papiamentu (Pp)) and *fə* (for Gullah), that have been considered as infinitival. They also made two important theoretical statements: 1) “basilects of IEPC’s are isolating, hence have no AGR features,” (p.307) which allowed them to posit that the *pro*/PRO distinction does not apply to IEPCs, and 2) the infinitive is defined by “its traditional morphological conception as one of those *inflections* which verbs assume when used in some prototypically nominal or non-verbal functions.” (p.302) Finally, Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) also contested the working definition of finiteness proposed by Koopman (1986, p.235) and showed that the finite/nonfinite distinction is disputable in IEPCs, and that the syntactic structures presented in their study can be described “without necessarily complicating the grammar with it.” (p.325)

For this study, we reanalyzed the data for HC and Pp in Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) in view of the theoretical considerations regarding the notion of finiteness proposed by Bianchi (2003), Landau (2004), and Adger (2007). These authors identified syntactical, functional, and semantic criteria associated with finiteness, which go beyond a simple morphological conception of it. We found that Koopman’s (1986) definition can properly account for the data presented in Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) provided that the definition is slightly refined. This, in turn, allowed us to argue in favor of keeping the distinction between finite/nonfinite clauses in HC (as supported by Koopman 1986) and Pp (as supported by Lefebvre & Therrien 2007), thus making the claim that these are not so “exceptional” or separate from Indo-European languages or other natural languages with regards to finiteness. Finally, we also found that the simple dichotomy finite/nonfinite is not enough to properly account for phenomena that Mufwene & Dijkhoff (1989) could not explain (p.316) and that in fact more distinctions and features, such as obviation and subjunctive mood, are needed.

Selected examples:

Presence or Absence of complementizers <i>que/that/pu/pa</i>			
Without complementizers <i>que/that/pu/pa</i>		With complementizers <i>que/that/pu/pa</i>	
French:	non-finite [+obviation]	French:	finite subjunctive [+obviation]
Marie _i veut	PRO _{i/*j} venir	Marie _i souhaite qu'	*(elle _{i/*j}) vienne
Marie _i veut	(*Ia _{i/j}) venir		
English:	non-finite [+obviation]	English:	finite "subjunctive" [-obviation]
Mary _i wishes	PRO _{i/*j} to come	Mary _i wishes that	*(she _{i/j}) came
Mary _i wishes	her _{i/j} to come		
Haitian Creole:	non-finite [+obviation]	Haitian Creole:	finite "subjunctive" [-obviation]
Mari _i lé	PRO _{i/*j} vini	Mari _i lé	pu *(I _{i/j}) vini
Mari _i lé	I _{i/j} vini		
Papiamentu:	non-finite [+obviation]	Papiamentu:	finite "subjunctive" [-obviation]
Mi _i ke	PRO _{i/*j} bin	Mi _i ke	pa *(mi _{i/j}) bin
?E _i ke	e _{i/j} bin		

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